

INDIAN MUSIC

DELHI

Delhi

The modern raga

Music talent hunts have been a shot in the arm for gurukuls teaching classical music. The tuning of the tanpura is, for many, synonymous now with the tinkling of cash registers.



DIFFERENT TUNES: Sawani (centre) with her students

RAVI S SAHANI

■ By S. Sahaya Ranjit

There was a time when classical gurus spurned film music and didn't take kindly to the odd shishya who wanted to go that way. That was then. Now, Devangi Mistry, 13, periodically records film songs and seeks her guru Sawani Mudgal's advice. "She is focused and wants to be a playback singer. I also teach her voice modulation in the Western style," says Mudgal, who, at 24, is the youngest teacher at Gandharva Mahavidyalaya, Delhi. A young woman, she can relate to them and has realistic expectations from her students.

"Even if they don't become singers, I get the satisfaction that they will become good *rasiks* (listeners) with an ear for refined music," says Mudgal.

The tradition of students performing on stage only after years of rigorous training and with their guru's permission has been replaced by a less formal one-to-one way of teaching. "I have been coming here for the past four years," says Harsimran Kaur, 12. The sheer enthusiasm of learning something they enjoy is evident on the campus of this modern-day gurukul. While one tunes a

tanpura in a corner, another straightens out the carpet for the guru. Thanks to the talent hunt shows, all that the students desire now is to make it big in life.

The success of Mahavidyalaya alumni like Kailash Kher and Richa Sharma further motivates them. "Most of our children are auditioned before they are admitted. There is a huge rush for classical vocal training," says principal Madhup Mudgal. "Earlier children wanted to become doctors and engineers, today they want to be playback singers," says Sawani. Fame is the ultimate fantasy.

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AGE OF
YOUNGEST
TEACHER AT
GURUKUL